escaped to the mountains and gained the support of the tribesmen. He also secured aid from the Saudi government. The army officers declared Yemen a republic and sought Nasser's aid. Nasser thought such aid would be required only on a small scale and for a short period of time. Yet, by 1965, he had 70,000 troops there and only finally withdrew, having got bogged down in a guerrilla war, in 1967. As he later admitted: it was 'a miscalculation: we never thought it would lead to what it did'.

Nasser, the Arabs and Israel 1963–7

Key question
Why did Nasser hold a conference of Arab leaders in 1964?

Despite these setbacks, Nasser was still a towering figure in the Arab world and the best-known Arab leader on the international stage. In 1963 there were further military coups in both Syria and Iraq and the new governments looked to Nasser to form a 'new movement of Arab unity'. The plans came to nothing but Nasser saw the need for joint Arab action to face a new threat from Israel. The Israelis were about to complete a project to divert 75 per cent of the water from the River Jordan to Israel for irrigation and industrial development. This was seen as a great threat to Syria and Jordan, both of which depended on water from the river.

Nasser presented the Israeli project as an act of aggression and a challenge to the whole Arab world, not just to Syria and Jordan which would be most affected. The young hotheads in the new Syrian government talked of taking military action but Nasser knew the Arab states were not prepared for war and that Israel had far stronger military forces. So he called for a conference of Arab leaders in Cairo in January 1964. This was attended by kings and presidents, allies and rivals, all united in opposition to Israel. At the conference, the leaders agreed to set up the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) to represent the Palestinian people in the struggle for the 'liberation of Palestine'. In effect, the Arab leaders had postponed the issue of how to deal with the Israeli threat but had put on a show of solidarity.

Over the next three years the Syrian government actively supported the PLO in launching guerrilla raids into Israel. Nasser did not yet want war with Israel because many of his forces were involved in Yemen. Besides, he knew that Israel was a stronger military power than Syria and Egypt combined. Yet he felt drawn to support radical, Arab nationalists, especially in the struggle with Israel. In August 1966, the Egyptian government announced: 'Damascus [the capital of Syria] does not stand alone against imperialist plots.'

Egypt then signed a defence agreement with Syria which stated that aggression against either state would be considered an attack on the other. Nasser rose again as the outstanding champion of the Arab cause. But the agreement with Syria paved the way for the chain of events that led to a disastrous war for the Arab states of Egypt, Syria and Jordan. This war, in 1967, which is known as the Six-Day War, was examined in Chapter 3.

Key dates

Nasser sent military aid to the Yemen: 1962–7

Conference of Arab leaders in Cairo: 1964

Formation of the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO): 1964

Six-Day War: 1967